

reproduction of textbook answers. Institutions must reward initiative, experimentation, and problem-solving, not memory alone. Entrepreneurs must have pathways for recovery, re-entry, and reinvention when ventures fail. A nation that stops trying out of fear of failure also stops moving towards success.

From campus to company

If innovation is to become a national strength, it must begin while people are still learning. Colleges and universities cannot remain places where knowledge is transmitted but not translated. They must become places where ideas are tested against reality.

That means encouraging students to build devices, write systems, develop software, solve local engineering problems, work on prototypes, and interact with industry earlier. The student who tries to build a working system learns design trade-offs, constraints, failure modes, and user realities in a way that no examination alone can teach. When institutions normalise that experience, they do more than educate. They begin to produce founders, inventors, product leaders, and industrial problem-solvers.

The bridge between education and the economy, therefore, does not start after graduation. It starts when learning becomes creation.

A national mandate

Innovation at a national level requires both scale and funding. Leading economies are built through numerous serious attempts across sectors, regions, and institutions.

India must support ideas at scale and fund them adequately. Underfunded innovation often fails before it can be properly tested. Support of the order of ₹50 million per idea gives capable teams room to build prototypes, test markets, refine designs, and demonstrate commercial potential.

If we aim for about 10,000 ideas per major state or cluster, this creates nearly 200,000 attempts across the country. At ₹50 million per idea, that amounts to about ₹500 billion per state, or roughly ₹100 billion per year over five years. With 50% central support, the state share drops to about ₹50 billion per year, typically representing 2 to 5% of a state budget. For 20 states, the central share comes to about ₹1000 billion, around 2% of the national budget. Funding is therefore not beyond reach. Public support reduces early risk and enables attempts; private capital can scale those that show promise.

Most attempts will fail. That is how innovation systems work. The few that succeed can more than compensate for those failures, while creating industries, jobs, exports, and long-term value. Even unsuccessful attempts contribute to building experience and execution capability.

This is how innovation ecosystems are built: fund widely, accept failure, and repeat.

Final thoughts

Education builds human capability. Innovation converts that capability into economic value. That is the bridge India must strengthen.

It is not enough to produce graduates in large numbers. India must enable them to build, protect, commercialise, and scale what they create. When that happens, education stops ending in employment alone and begins generating products, companies, industries, and national wealth.

India already has the talent, the technical base, and the energy. What it now needs is a national system that converts those strengths into ownership and economic power. India has shown that it can build for the world. The next step is to build and own. That shift can turn education into economic leadership. **EFY**

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